

The Seagate 5.0 GB has a completely different design. It is doughnut-shaped, except for the hole, of course. The retractable USB cable is wound round the circumference, and the mechanism is excellent. A blue LED indicates drive activity.

Since these drives are meant to be carried around often, they ought to be light. All the drives are, indeed, small enough to easily fit in a pocket, and weigh very little, too. The Seagate 5.0 GB, which is quite old, and which was also featured in our external hard drive shootout of last year, was considered lightweight back then—it weighs just 63 grams. But this time round, this was the heaviest of the drives in this category! The LaCie weighs 60 grams, and the Qrisma 6 GB is the lightest of them all, tipping the scales at just 30 grams!

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LaCie
Carte Orange

Performance: Synthetic Tests HD Tach RW

The CPU utilisation of the drives in this category was very low—practically insignificant. As Random Access time goes, the Qrisma was the slowest, scoring 51.4 seconds, while the Seagate scored 26.1 seconds.

The Average Read and Write speeds of the LaCie and the Seagate drives were almost identical. The LaCie exhibited peculiar behaviour: while it scored the highest in the Average Read test with 7.4 MBps, it scored the lowest in the Average Write test with 3.3 MBps.

SiSoft Sandra 2007 Engineer

The Qrisma drive failed to complete the SiSoft Sandra test, and we repeated the test several times, but with the same result. We therefore had to leave it out of this test. The Seagate edged a little ahead of the LaCie drive in all the disk read and write tests. The LaCie was better by a tiny margin in the access timings.

Performance: Real-World Tests

We knew that real-world tests with these drives was going to be a pain, because microdrives are slow! When we transferred 1 GB of assorted files to the drives, the Qrisma was very slow,

taking 460 seconds. The LaCie and Seagate drives were faster, taking 287 and 299 seconds respectively. While copying the assorted files from the drive, the Qrisma was slower than the other two, but not by a large margin.

When we transferred the 1 GB sequential file to the drives (this tests the write performance of a drive), the Qrisma was again the slowest, taking 229 seconds, while the LaCie and Seagate got the job done in 187 and 169 seconds respectively. While copying the file from the drive, the picture was completely different: the Qrisma was the fastest at 120 seconds, while the Seagate took 128. The slowest here was the LaCie at 169 seconds.

We then performed the internal-transfer test on the drives. The Qrisma crawled, taking an impossible-sounding 2682 seconds for the assorted file and 2554 for the sequential file copy. The LaCie and the Seagate took 539 and 508 seconds respectively in the assorted file copy, and took 512 and 603 seconds respectively in the sequential file copy test.

The last test we conducted was the 1 GB assorted data transfer to and from the drive simultaneously, which, as we've mentioned earlier, stresses the drive mechanics to the utmost. Here, too, the Qrisma lagged behind by miles, taking 3024 seconds to copy the files, whereas the LaCie took 973 seconds and the Seagate took 696.

The Qrisma is without a doubt the slowest of the three drives in this category. But if you want a lightweight drive that's easy to carry around, and can put up with slow transfers, it's the drive for you.

Our Conclusion

As in the earlier two categories, price was taken into consideration in order to decide the winners. The Seagate 5.0 GB drive has the best cost per MB at 94 paise. The drive also performed better than the other two, and was therefore adjudged the winner of the Digit Best Buy Gold award.

The LaCie Carte Orange with its better features, rugged design and good performance was declared the winner of the Digit Best Buy Silver award.

So What's To Come?

The capacities of the external hard drives we tested rival those of their internal counterparts. This is primarily because internally, external drives are, after all, internal drives—they are only housed in an enclosure with an interface converter.

Some motherboard manufacturers have been advocating the use of SATA drives as external drives, providing brackets to externally connect a SATA drive without the need to open up the cabinet. If this trend catches peoples' fancy, then along with the growing number of SATA plug-n-play-capable motherboards, you can expect SATA drives to be used as external drives in the months to come. ■

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Contact Sheet		External Hard Drives		
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